



Two first-hand reports: Kingston told us about their near-future plans in India—and Toshiba about their new notebooks

Digit @ Kingston: Taiwan

Kingston invited several publications—including us—for their 20th anniversary celebrations. The press event was at Hsin-chu, the industrial capital of Taiwan. One of the highlights of the year for them was the recently-launched (October) HyperX series of DDR3 RAM.

The factory floor was suited up for the tour when we arrived; the assembly of all the products is done over line-ups of SMT (Surface Mount Technology) machines that run a few metres in length. The modules are then tested using visual scanners and then tested for working. The testing area is a huge hall with long lines of motherboards of all generations one after the other testing PC RAM modules and USB drives. There are also laptop setups for testing SO-DIMMs. Then there's the labelling and packaging area.

We managed to get talking with Nathan Su, product manager for Flash memory, and Ann Bai, product manager for DRAM memory, about Kingston's strategies and interests in India. Kingston has chosen to focus, in India, on the USB market (including memory cards and USB drives) more than PC memory, because of import duty issues, and because of

the huge mobile phone market here. They said would be working on their brand image with more promotions and, of course, continuing to keep up the competitive pricing on all their products.

We asked about DDR3, and Kingston told us they were actively working on that technology, but that they believed it would only pick up momentum towards the end of 2008 and early 2009. DDR3 modules are currently very expensive, and sales would only come from test labs, motherboard manufacturers,

According to Toshiba, the new models with HD-DVD will cost 8 to 10 per cent more than laptops with similar configurations and regular DVD SuperMulti drives (DVD-Writers). During the event, Toshiba announced six variants of the A200, of which four will be HD-ready.

Other goodies include a maximum storage capacity of 400 GB (200 x 2), ATI mobility Radeon HD2600 / X2400, 2 GB DDR2, a 15.4-inch WXGA Clear Superview display screen, and a plethora of connectivity options. All variants will be

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and a few enthusiasts. For now, DDR2 667MHz would be the most in demand, they said, and Kingston would go with it for now.

On solid state drives (SSD), Kingston's stand is that they would only see the light of the day through laptops. SSDs for Desktops would still be at least a year or so away due to high manufacturing costs and limited capacities.

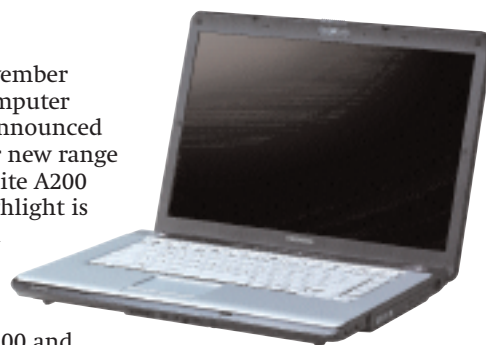
Toshiba's New Notebooks

Singapore, 6th November 2007, Toshiba's Computer Systems Division announced the launch of their new range of affordable Satellite A200 notebooks. The highlight is the inclusion of an HD-DVD drive and HDMI connectivity.

The Satellite A100 and A200 series from Toshiba were oriented towards value-conscious buyers, and have had reasonably good configurations. With the inclusion of HD-DVD and HDMI connectivity, the A200 will be able to play HD content on the laptop screen; one can opt to enjoy the high definition on a larger screen via the HDMI connectivity, which supports resolutions up to 1080i. The HDMI connector also allows the laptop to be connected to Audio/Video receivers.

powered by Intel Core 2 Duo processors and Windows Vista Home Premium.

The inclusion of HD-DVD doesn't really matter for Indian consumers, but 8 to 10 per cent is a reasonable price difference to pay for being future-proof. The exact prices weren't declared, but expect to pay around Rs 60,000 for the base model, and more for high-end configurations.



Toshiba also announced its go-green initiative called Notebook-2-recycle: they are now offering to recycle its notebooks free of cost, free of any obligation to buy a new Toshiba notebook—just call the global support centre, and a pickup will be arranged. In Phase One, the service will start in Singapore; Phase Two will include Thailand, Malaysia, and Indonesia; and in the final phase, it will be rolled out in all of Southeast Asia. ■